

Medieval western Europe

The period between the 5th and 15th centuries was an era of great change for western Europe. New kingdoms emerged and grew rich, yet this was also a time of constant warfare and widespread poverty. Power and wealth belonged to the monarchs, the nobles, and the Church, while the vast majority of people remained poor.

After the fall of the Western Roman Empire in 476 CE, new cultures influenced by Roman, Germanic, and Celtic traditions took hold across the continent. Around the same period, Christianity rapidly spread and new nations were born led by Christian monarchs.

By the 10th century, much of Europe was organized into a feudal system, in which kings gave land to the nobility,



ISLAMIC KINGDOMS ►

In the 8th century, Muslims from North Africa conquered Spain. They brought new foods, such as oranges and almonds, and new technologies, and introduced a unique style of Islamic architecture. One of the most beautiful examples is the Alhambra palace in Granada, which was built by the Nasrid Dynasty—the last of the Islamic kingdoms to fall to Christian rulers in 1492.

who, in return, provided them with armies during wartime. At the bottom of this system were the peasants, who worked the land.

At this time, culture and art across Europe began to flourish. The first university in Europe was founded in the 11th century, and advances in art and architecture gave rise to brilliant artworks and buildings that survive to this day.

Toward the end of the 15th century, the medieval period gave way to the Renaissance (see pp.104–105), when an explosion of new ideas transformed western Europe yet again.

◀ KNIGHTS

Knights were an elite class of horseback warriors who fought in times of war for the king or queen. In peacetime, they demonstrated their fighting skills at jousting tournaments—in which two knights would charge each other with long lances—a popular form of entertainment.



▲ THE CRUSADES

From the 11th to the 13th centuries, Christian armies from Europe fought a series of religious wars known as the Crusades against Muslim forces in the eastern Mediterranean. The Crusaders, which included warriors such as Richard the Lionheart (above), wanted to regain Jerusalem—a sacred place for Christianity and Islam—from Muslim control, but their campaign ultimately failed.



▲ POWER OF THE CHURCH

The Catholic Church's power grew rapidly during this period, eventually holding a huge influence over everyday medieval life. Elaborate churches and cathedrals, such as Beauvais Cathedral in France (above), were built as spectacular monuments to God.

